

The Meeting Has Already Started



A critique of
ableist design defaults
and a case for community-led
accessibility

zine by allies

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Over **1 billion people** live with disability worldwide. Most video conferencing tools weren't designed with any of them in mind.

— WHO, 2022 / Hersh et al., 2024

The empty chair.

This zine looks at *Zoom* — one of the most widely used video conferencing platforms in the world — through the lens of disability justice.

Who was centered in its design?
Who was left out?

And what would it look like to build these tools differently?

Accessibility isn't a feature. It's a question of who gets to participate.



Zoom, accessibility, and design.

During the pandemic, Zoom became how we worked, learned, and stayed connected.

But convenience for some meant barriers for others.

For many disabled users, just joining a meeting means navigating systems never built for them.



But participation came with a price.

In 2020, Zoom placed captioning behind a \$200/month paywall. After a year into the pandemic, it was removed, but even now, captions can only be turned on by the meeting host.

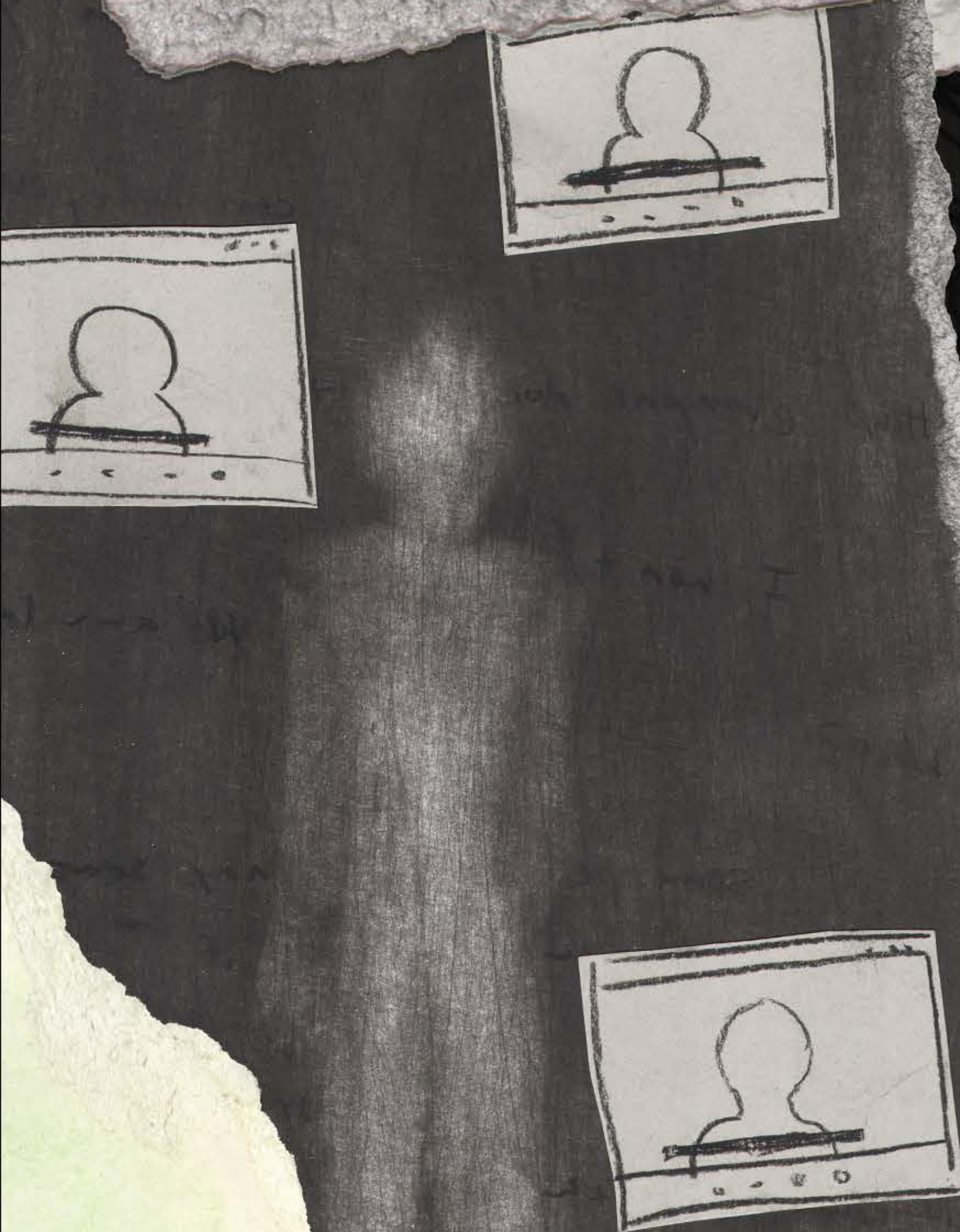
Zoom's automated captions are less accurate than those on other platforms. And even when screen reader functions technically exist, they require too many steps to be practical.

The cost wasn't just technical.

Poor audio makes lip-reading, which is a key strategy for people with hearing loss, much harder. Zoom doesn't just fail to accommodate. It removes tools people already have.

“Imagine **seven months of social isolation**, not only from in-person visits with your friends and family, but also without the ability to converse comfortably with them, virtually either.”

— Shari Eberts, hearing health advocate
(O'Dowd & Hagan, 2020)



Many disabled users don't have control over their environment. Disturbances can interfere directly with the accessibility tools they rely on.

Furthermore, schools and workplaces often don't provide the equipment needed, leaving users to handle the cost themselves. The meeting kept going. Not everyone could follow.

By design.

Zoom's accessibility gaps aren't accidents. They reflect a design process that treated disabled users as an afterthought — never centered, rarely consulted.

The following three frameworks ask something different: what do users already know, and why weren't they in the room when this was built?

Design Justice

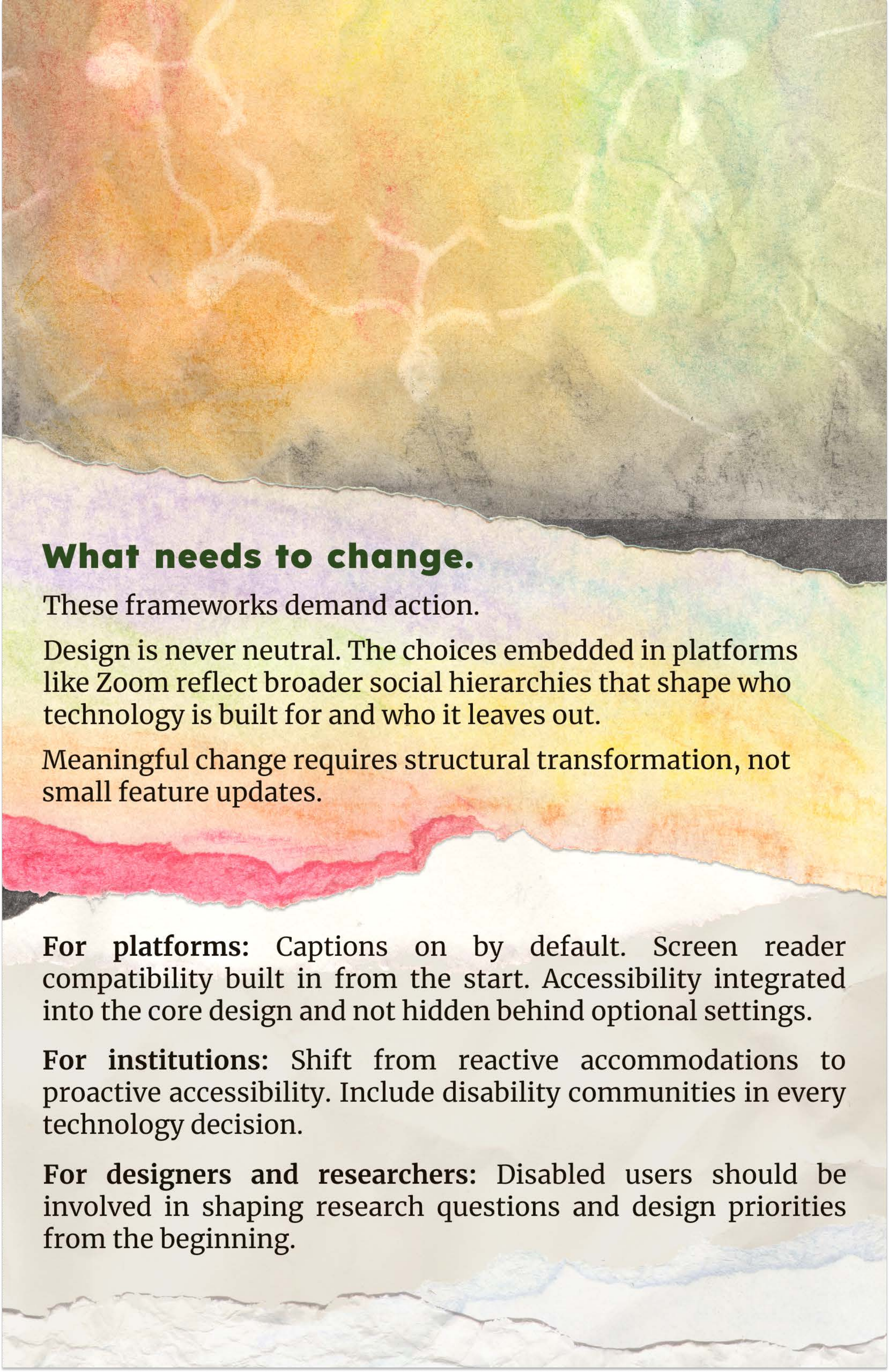
— Everyone is an expert based on their own lived experience. Disabled users should shape design from the start, not be consulted after the fact.

Ability-Based Design

— Systems should adapt to users' abilities, not the other way around. This means considering multiple ways people participate and not assuming speech and video as the default.

Assets-Based Design

— Users already have knowledge, strategies, and strengths. Design should build on what people bring, not treat them as problems to solve.



What needs to change.

These frameworks demand action.

Design is never neutral. The choices embedded in platforms like Zoom reflect broader social hierarchies that shape who technology is built for and who it leaves out.

Meaningful change requires structural transformation, not small feature updates.

For platforms: Captions on by default. Screen reader compatibility built in from the start. Accessibility integrated into the core design and not hidden behind optional settings.

For institutions: Shift from reactive accommodations to proactive accessibility. Include disability communities in every technology decision.

For designers and researchers: Disabled users should be involved in shaping research questions and design priorities from the beginning.

**Accessibility can be reimagined as
collective empowerment rather
than individual accommodation.**



This zine exists because critical scholarship should reach the communities it's about. Scan the QR code or click this [link](#) to read our full essay.



**Design with.
Not for.**